

BHASKAR PAUL

Mukesh

MR MONEY

"It is all notional," he told his shareholders at the AGM. When you are Mukesh Ambani, you can afford to say wealth is simply a notion. But there is nothing notional about the wealth created by the "money machine". Lesser mortals would still be nursing the split of 2006. Not Mukesh. If at all, it seems to have spurred him on. Between January 2006, when the group was demerged and December 2007, the market capitalisation of Reliance Industries (RIL) has trebled to Rs 3,93,000 crore. RIL makes Rs 14 crore an hour and this year, it will make Rs 1,28,000 crore in sales and a net profit of about Rs 15,000 crore. If all this is dizzying stuff consider the inside view of the future. At the current rates of investment, growth and return, RIL—thanks to revenue from businesses like refinery, exploration and retail—should touch a turnover of over Rs 3,00,000 crore by 2010 taking its market capitalisation to somewhere around Rs 6,00,000 crore. At around that time, Mukesh would be worth \$100 billion (Rs 4,00,000 crore). Now isn't that a pleasant notion?

by Shankkar Aiyar

RIL IS EXPECTED

to touch a turnover of over Rs 3,00,000 cr by 2010, which will take its market capitalisation to Rs 6,00,000 cr

SHAKESH KAVIA

Narendra Modi

ONE MAN ARMY

Four months after Narendra Modi became chief minister of Gujarat in late 2001, Godhra happened. Since then, no chief minister in the country has hogged as many headlines and dominated the news as much as the 57-year-old RSS pracharak. And never has an assembly election centred around one individual. Five years after he led BJP to victory in the elections that followed the Godhra massacre, the country's politics is witnessing an upheaval of epic proportions as Modi stays the party's mascot in the ongoing polls. Once again, the polity has been polarised. It is as if the elections are less about choosing a new government and more a referendum on Modi. If vast sections of the media are to be believed, Modi is The Devil. The outrage would have been enough to force BJP to banish any other individual on a long *vanvas*. But as 2002 showed, millions of Gujaratis also see him as a saviour. So if the party persists with Modi, it is acknowledgment that at the moment, it doesn't have a better talisman.

by Ashok K. Damodaran

IT IS AS IF the elections are less about choosing a new regime in Gandhinagar and more of a referendum on Modi

